

Paper Title

Author Name

Abstract—

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I. INTRODUCTION

Deep learning has achieved strong performance in many radar applications, including target detection, classification, and recognition. Its performance, however, depends strongly on the quantity, diversity, and annotation quality of the available data. This dependence is particularly restrictive for maritime radar because existing measured datasets cover only a limited set of sea states, radar parameters, viewing geometries, and target conditions. A model trained on such data may not generalize to an unobserved wind speed, wave direction, grazing angle, or clutter regime. Expanding a measured dataset is also difficult: sea experiments require suitable platforms, radar equipment, environmental sensors, synchronized observations, and favorable weather, while a desired sea condition cannot be reproduced on demand. The shortage and limited diversity of measured radar data have therefore become a major constraint on the development of data-driven maritime sensing methods.

Numerical simulation provides a practical way to supplement measured data because environmental and radar parameters can be controlled independently and a large number of labeled samples can be generated repeatedly. For radar applications, however, computational efficiency alone is insufficient. A simulated sea surface must preserve the statistical roughness of the background sea, respond reasonably to different wind and wave conditions, and represent the local structures that produce strong or non-Gaussian radar returns. High-fidelity hydrodynamic methods can resolve nonlinear wave evolution and breaking interfaces in detail, but their computational and storage costs make them difficult to use for the rapid generation of large radar datasets over many environmental conditions. Spectral sea-surface models are considerably more efficient, but a conventional linear realization does not explicitly represent strongly nonlinear or overturning crests. A useful data-generation method must therefore balance physical credibility, environmental adaptability, computational cost, and compatibility with radar scattering calculations.

Sea-surface roughness is inherently multiscale. Long gravity waves determine the large-scale tilt and motion of the surface, whereas shorter wind waves modify local slopes and radar-resonant components. Consequently, the observed return depends jointly on sea state, incidence angle, radar wavelength, and surface geometry. High-resolution measurements show that sea clutter may exhibit pronounced non-Gaussian tails and intermittent sea spikes, which can be confused with target responses [?], [?], [?], [?], [?]. Directional wave spectra, such as the unified Elfouhaily spectrum, provide an efficient description of the gravity and gravity-capillary energy

distribution [?]. Nevertheless, a linear spectral realization is approximately Gaussian and mainly preserves second-order statistics. Nonlinear hydrodynamic interactions sharpen crests, smooth troughs, and change the distributions of slopes and curvatures, thereby influencing the scattering coefficient and Doppler spectrum [?]. The sea-surface skewness function and its small-scale-wave parameter also affect the upwind-downwind asymmetry of radar backscattering [?], while convolutions of short-wave spectral components can contribute appreciably to the normalized backscattering cross section under different radar frequencies, wind speeds, and incidence angles [?]. Thus, a radar-oriented sea model should represent not only the total spectral energy but also nonlinear crest geometry and the directional organization of shorter wind waves.

The return from an ordinary rough sea surface is commonly described by quasi-specular, Bragg, or two-scale scattering formulations. Their relative contributions vary with incidence angle, and both quasi-specular and Bragg mechanisms may be required in the transition range [?]. Radar observations of marine film slicks further suggest that the source of short wind waves can depend on propagation direction and cannot always be represented by conventional wind-input terms alone [?]. For steep and breaking waves, additional scattering mechanisms become important. Numerical and experimental studies have related low-grazing-angle sea spikes to steepening or breaking crests [?], [?], [?]. Full-wave and hybrid models have investigated crest diffraction, rough-face scattering, and multipath interactions [?], [?], [?], [?], [?]. Facet-based methods have introduced breaking-wave contributions into larger sea surfaces and analyzed their effects on normalized radar cross section (NRCS), sea spikes, and synthetic aperture radar images [?]. Three-dimensional plunging-breaker models combined with ray tracing have also shown that a breaker crest can generate target-like peaks in radar cross section and high-resolution range profiles [?].

These studies establish the electromagnetic importance of nonlinear and breaking waves, but most emphasize scattering from prescribed breaker profiles or local surfaces produced by relatively expensive numerical solvers. They do not directly provide a rapid procedure for generating large numbers of spatially extended, environmentally controllable sea surfaces for radar dataset construction. Directly adding an independent short-wave field to a spectral surface may duplicate energy in the selected band, whereas a conventional single-valued nonlinear height field cannot form the forward extension and overturning facets of a plunging crest. It is therefore still difficult to preserve the large-area slope statistics of the background sea, organize the shorter wind waves along a dominant propagation direction, introduce localized curling geometry, and retain a computational cost suitable for batch

radar simulation within one framework.

This letter proposes a hierarchical sea-surface simulation method intended for rapid radar-data generation under variable environmental conditions. First, an Elfouhaily directional spectrum and a wind-dependent nonlinear Lie transformation are used to construct a statistically constrained nonlinear background surface. Second, a selected short-wave band is replaced by an equal-energy directional component, forming shorter wind-wave ridges with a prescribed dominant propagation direction without repeatedly injecting spectral energy. Third, candidate crests are identified from elevation, propagation-direction slope, and curvature, after which a compactly supported coordinate transformation generates a localized forward-extending and downward-curling breaker. Wind speed, wind direction, directional spreading, short-wave scale, and local curling parameters can be varied to produce different sea-surface realizations, while the facet representation allows the generated surfaces to be used directly in radar scattering and echo simulations. Compared with resolving every realization through a high-fidelity hydrodynamic solver, the proposed method is designed to generate physically interpretable sea surfaces at substantially lower computational cost and is therefore suitable for producing large, controllable synthetic radar datasets.

The method is evaluated from surface geometry to radar observables. The background and short-wave-enriched surfaces are first examined using spectral consistency and along-wind and crosswind mean-square slopes under different wind conditions. The localized breaker is then assessed using crest geometry, facet-orientation statistics, radar-facing projected area, and paired unit-footprint scattering enhancement. Finally, radar echoes generated from the complete surface are evaluated through range–time intensity, temporal correlation, and amplitude-distribution statistics. Section II presents the hierarchical surface model. Section III describes the validation metrics and radar echo generation. Section IV reports the numerical and experimental comparisons, and Section V concludes this letter.

REFERENCES